

type: Assignment
track: "[[General AI Fluency]]"
week: 3
phase: Foundations
status: ● Complete
tags:
date: 17/07/2026
name: "Kill you Darlings: Curate Your Images"

Meta & Objectives

- **Why it matters:** AI makes image generation easy, but the real skill is judgment: choosing visuals that prove the work, look consistent, and do not distract from the portfolio.
- **The Brief:** Map the images my portfolio actually needs, choose mostly real captures of my work, use AI only for connective visuals, reject images that do not serve the proof, and document where I chose real screenshots over AI.

Final Image Set — The Keepers

#	Portfolio need	Final image choice	Real or AI-generated?	Why it belongs
1	Portfolio hero section	Subtle abstract grid / node texture using the FL-03 palette	AI-generated	This gives the homepage a technical atmosphere without pretending to show real work.
2	Personal/about section	Real photo of me	Real photo	Since the subject is me, it should be real, not AI-generated.
3	Main portfolio/project overview	Screenshot of my portfolio homepage or project index	Real capture	This proves the portfolio exists and shows the actual interface.
4	RAG / agentic project case study	Screenshot of the app running: API response, chat interface, or workflow screen	Real capture	A real screenshot shows the actual system better than a generated mockup.
5	Backend/API debugging case study	Cropped terminal screenshot showing logs, Docker Compose services, or fixed API response	Real capture	This is evidence of real engineering work and debugging process.
6	Cybersecurity / CTF case study	Cropped screenshot of a terminal, Ghidra/radare2 view, or challenge-solving notes	Real capture	The work is technical and proof-based, so a real capture is more credible than AI art.
7	Research / paper analysis workflow	Screenshot of structured notes, paper summary table, or graph/research diagram	Real capture	This shows my actual research workflow instead of a generic "AI research" image.
8	Project cards / category icons	Small line icons for AI, cybersecurity, backend, and research	AI-generated or manually created	These are decorative navigation aids, not proof of work, so generated icons are acceptable if consistent.

#	Portfolio need	Final image choice	Real or AI-generated?	Why it belongs
9	Favicon/logo	Simple Y monogram from the identity kit	Manually created SVG	It keeps the visual identity consistent across the site.
10	Track / learning evidence	Screenshot of AI Fluency, Claude Project, or prompt iteration notes	Real capture	This directly supports the AI Fluency coursework and shows real progress.

Image Style Rules

Rule	Decision
Work proof	Use real screenshots only
Personal image	Use a real photo only
AI-generated visuals	Use only for background texture or small icons
Cropping	Clean, tight, and legible
Visual mood	Calm, technical, precise, research-oriented
Palette	#2563EB , #111827 , #F9FAFB , #22C55E
Avoid	Fake dashboards, fake code, fake terminal screenshots, cyberpunk clichés, neon hacker art

AI Image Prompt Used for Connective Visuals

Prompt for hero texture / background:

Create a minimal abstract technical background for a cybersecurity and AI research portfolio. Use a calm near-black and blue palette with small green signal accents. The image should feel like a subtle network graph, terminal grid, or research map, but it must stay minimal and not look like a dramatic hacker poster. No text, no fake code, no fake dashboards, no people. Clean, professional, quiet, precise.

Prompt for small icons:

Create a consistent set of minimal line icons for a technical portfolio. Icons needed: AI systems, cybersecurity, backend engineering, research notes. Use simple geometric strokes, rounded corners, and a calm technical mood. No gradients, no complex details, no text, no fake logos. The icons should work at small sizes and match a minimal blue/green portfolio identity.

Where I Chose Real Captures Over AI

Portfolio section	Decision	Reason
RAG / agentic project	Real app screenshot instead of AI-generated interface	The point is to prove that the system works, so a fake interface would weaken trust.
Backend/API debugging	Real terminal/log screenshot instead of generated terminal art	Real logs show actual engineering evidence and are more credible.
Cybersecurity / CTF work	Real tool screenshot instead of "hacker" illustration	CTF and security work should be proof-based, not aesthetic-only.
Research workflow	Real notes or paper summary screenshot instead of generic AI research image	The value is in my actual method, not a stock-looking research visual.
About section	Real photo instead of AI avatar	Since the image represents me, it should be authentic.

Rejected Image Note

I rejected a generated "cyberpunk hacker room" style hero image because it looked dramatic but did not support my portfolio proof. It made the page feel like a generic cybersecurity poster instead of a calm AI/cybersecurity research portfolio.

I also rejected fake dashboard-style generated images because they looked polished but dishonest. For project case studies, real screenshots of my actual app, logs, notes, and tools are stronger than any generated mockup.

Final Track Thread Summary

For my image curation assignment, I mapped the portfolio images around real proof instead of decoration.

The final set uses mostly real captures: screenshots of my portfolio, RAG/agent project, backend logs, CTF/security work, research notes, and AI Fluency progress. I chose a real personal photo for the about section because anything representing me should be authentic.

I only use AI-generated images for connective tissue: a subtle hero texture and small matching icons. These follow the same calm technical identity from my kit: #2563EB blue, #111827 near-black, #F9FAFB near-white, and #22C55E as a small signal accent.

The main image I rejected was a dramatic cyberpunk hacker-style visual. It looked cool, but it competed with the work and made the portfolio feel generic. I chose real screenshots instead because the portfolio should prove what I built, not just look technical.

AI Collaboration Log

- **Initial Draft / Thought Process:**
 - My first instinct was to use generated visuals for the portfolio because they are fast and polished.
 - After mapping the content, I realized most images should be real screenshots because my work is technical and proof-based.
- **The Friction Points:**
 - The hardest part was separating visuals that make the portfolio look cool from visuals that actually prove the work.
 - Generated cyber images were tempting, but many looked generic and made the portfolio less credible.
 - I also had to avoid fake interfaces, fake code, and fake dashboards because they would weaken trust.
- **Refinements Made:**
 - I kept real screenshots for all project case studies.
 - I limited AI-generated images to background texture and icons only.
 - I matched the generated style to the identity kit: calm, technical, minimal, and research-oriented.
 - I added a rejection note that explains why a visually attractive image was still the wrong choice.